▼ GLASSHOUSE



IT'S A SMALL WORLD

Operation Sindoor's global pitch comes with an elite twist. Seven members of India's diplomatic outreach squads are alumni of Delhi's St Stephen's College, including Congress leaders **Shashi Tharoor** and **Salman Khurshid,** diplomats **Harsh Vardhan Shringla, Taranjit Sandhu, Jawed Ashraf** and **Manjeev Puri,** and MEA supremo **S. Jaishankar.** But those aren't the only absolutes. All seven outreach delegations also have at least one Muslim leader, a symbolic counter to the communal criticisms swirling back home. Three teams are led by Opposition MPs—Tharoor (Congress), Kanimozhi (DMK) and Supriya Sule (NCP-SP)—making this perhaps the most bipartisan foreign mission since Narasimha Rao's gambit to send A.B. Vajpayee to Geneva in 1994.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ WORDLE SCORE

THE CASTE ALPHABET



The Samajwadi Party's PDA formula is fast turning into a linguistic Rubik's cube. Initially coined as a smart acronym for Pichhda, Dalit and Alpsankhyak (Backwards, Dalits and Minorities), it was party chief **Akhilesh Yadav's** attempt to rebrand his party, take it beyond the M-Y (Muslim-Yadav) baseline. But, of late, Akhilesh is stretching PDA to mean whatever he wants it to, so that A can be for Agda (upper caste) or Apmanit (the humiliated), and P for Patrakar (journalist) and Pandit alike. Through all this, 'D' had been the one constant, signifying the Dalits, but even that changed at a recent press conference—PDA became Peedit, Dukhi, Apmanit (basically, anyone with a grievance). The shifting semantics has left even the party workers scratching their heads.